for the party in the region, went so far as to write that the party's 'North-East foot-soldiers like to call it the Bharatiya Jesus Party!' However, they noted that the BJP will have to 'go through ideological churning afresh. Its hitherto majoritarian outlook would need to give some political space to a "minority darshan" or philosophy.'[62] It was the kind of flexibility that led the BJP's opponents, like Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi, to quip tongue-in-cheek: 'BJP's hypocrisy is that in Uttar Pradesh cow is mummy but in the Northeast it's yummy.'[63]

The constant tension caused by this balancing act is best illustrated by the flip-flops of two BJP central ministers on the beef issue in 2015. It began with Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi, then minister of state for parliamentary affairs and Rajya Sabha MP from UP, who declared at a media conclave, 'Those who are dying without eating beef can go to Pakistan or Arab countries or any other part of world where it is available.' He added, 'Even Muslims are against it.'[64] A week later, Kiren Rijiju, then minister of state for home and BJP MP from Arunachal Pradesh, retorted at a press conference in Aizawl: 'I'm from Arunachal Pradesh, can somebody stop me? So let us not be touchy about somebody's practices … This is a democratic country. Sometimes, some statements are made which are not palatable.'[65] Rijiju later claimed that he had been misquoted, strongly denied that he personally ate beef and insisted that he was speaking hypothetically about how no one could stop individual food choices. 'To calm down the situation, I had the responsibility as a Union minister whereby I gave a hypothetical example of myself that I am from Arunachal Pradesh and if I have a particular food habit, no one can stop.'[66]

Rijiju's argument, essentially, was this: different states, different rules. As he put it, 'If a Mizo Christian says that this is the land of Jesus, why should someone have a problem in Punjab or Haryana? We have to honour the sentiments of each place and each location … If Maharashtra is Hindu majority, or if Gujarat is Hindu majority, Madhya Pradesh is Hindu majority, if they are to make laws which are conducive to the Hindu faith, let them be. But in our place, in our state where we are majority, where we feel